Task	CTC	Mask-mixing gain
BEIR FiQA	$O_T(N)$	**+0.011**
Outlier (scale-k)	$O_T(NM)$	**+0.505**
QDmatch (FiQA)	$O_T(N^2)$	**+0.031**
Reordering†	$O_T(N^2)$	**+0.182**
Contradiction†	$O_T(N^2)$	**+0.791**

Table 1: **What curriculum mask-mixing buys, by corpus-traversal complexity.** Both chunked arms use the identical document-chunked mask at evaluation time and differ only in training: *+Mix* anneals a per-step unrestricted-attention coin $p_{\text{standard}}: 0.8 \to 0$, *Chunked* never sees an unrestricted step. *Gain* is (+Mix) $-$ (Chunked). Qwen3.5-4B, identical shards, identical ladders, matched hyperparameters; $eval\_size =$ 500 per rung, so a gain under ~ 0.04 is within noise. Each figure is the mean per-rung gain over the 2k–32k ladder (5 rungs; reordering stops at 16k, 4 rungs). Mixing is worth nothing on $O_T(N)$ retrieval (FiQA, +0.011) and is the difference between learning the task and not learning it at all on contradiction (+0.791) and outlier detection (+0.505). *Reordering and QDmatch earn their entire gain at the shallow rungs*: by the deepest rung the full-attention arm has itself fallen below 0.15, leaving no headroom for either chunked arm, so their gains run +0.473 and -0.073 at 2k but $+0.000$ and $+0.006$ at the bottom of the ladder. †Pure-chunked training cross-entropy never descended on these two tasks (contradiction: $1.175 \to 1.071$, flat across the whole run), while FiQA and QDmatch on the identical recipe converged normally – so the collapse is task-specific rather than an infrastructure failure, but it reflects a failure to fit the training set and is not by itself a statement about what the mask can represent.